INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #1 · PARENTS

“My parents never loved me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Some of us grew up with parents who were distant, harsh, absent, addicted, or simply unable to show love in a way we could feel. Children draw their conclusions from what they experience, and a child who did not feel loved often decides, “I was unlovable,” or “they never loved me.” That conclusion can then shape friendships, marriage, and even how we imagine God.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest that parents can fail. The psalmist says, “Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me.” God is called “a father of the fatherless,” and “God settles the lonely in families.” Jeremiah records God’s words, “I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have drawn you with loving devotion.” John says, “Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God. And that is what we are!” Even if human love fell short, God’s love for you is not in question. A parent’s failure to show love is a real wound, but it is not a verdict on your worth.

> *“Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me”* (Psalm 27:10).

Also see

> “The LORD appeared to us in the past, saying: ‘I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have drawn you with loving devotion.’” (Jeremiah 31:3).

> “A father of the fatherless, and a defender of the widows, is God in His holy habitation. God settles the lonely in families; He leads the prisoners out to prosperity, but the rebellious dwell in a sun-scorched land” (Psalm 68:5–6).

> “Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God. And that is what we are! The reason the world does not know us is that it did not know Him” (1 John 3:1).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

Common self-statements

- I was never wanted.
- There must be something wrong with me or they would have loved me.
- No one will ever love me the way a parent should.
- I do not matter to the people who should care most.
- Love is for other people.
- I will always feel unloved.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unloved and concluding that I was and am unlovable.
- Personalization: Believing their failure to love was caused by something wrong in me.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing parents as either fully loving or never loving at all.
- Overgeneralizing: Letting one painful relationship define all love.

Challenging questions

- What did I actually experience from my parents, and what conclusions did I draw as a child?
- Were there any moments, however small, when I was cared for?
- What might have been going on in my parents that kept them from loving well?
- Is a parent's inability to love the same as my being unlovable?
- What does God say about how He sees me?
- Who in my life now shows me love?

Truth summary

> My parents' failure to love me well was real and painful, but it does not define my worth. God has loved me with an everlasting love, and He receives me as His child. I can grieve what I missed and receive what God and His people offer now.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Loneliness
- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My parents never loved me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My parents never loved me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I experience from my parents?
- ☐ What conclusions did I draw as a child?
- ☐ Who loves me now?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What do I need to grieve?
- ☐ Who can I talk with about this?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is not decided by how my parents treated me.
- ☐ God has loved me with an everlasting love.
- ☐ The Lord receives me.
- ☐ God settles the lonely in families.
- ☐ I am a child of God.
- ☐ I can receive love now.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 27:10
  "Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me."
- ☐ Jeremiah 31:3
  "The LORD appeared to us in the past, saying: 'I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have drawn you with loving devotion.'"
- ☐ 1 John 3:1
  "Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God. And that is what we are! The reason the world does not know us is that it did not know Him."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Love received: Each day, write one way you received love or kindness from God or from another person.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 27:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Even if my parents failed me, the Lord receives me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Love, By God" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write the story honestly. Describe what you experienced and what you concluded as a child. Pray over it.
- [ ] Grieve what you missed. Allow sadness for what you did not receive, with a trusted listener if possible.
- [ ] Name people who love you. List three people or communities who care for you now.
- [ ] Read 1 John 3:1 aloud. Say it each morning for a week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My parents never loved me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Love received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My parents never loved me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You see the places where I did not feel loved. Receive me, heal what was hurt, and let me know that I am Your child. Bring people into my life who show Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #2 · PARENTS

"I can never please my parents."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Some parents set standards that keep moving. A good grade is met with "why not an A-plus," a success is met with silence, and a mistake is remembered for years. Children of such homes often grow into adults who work hard to earn approval that never comes, and who feel on edge around their parents even decades later.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks, "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ." The psalmist says, "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made." Scripture does call us to honor our father and mother, but honor is not the same as winning their approval. Honor can mean respect, kindness, and care, offered without needing their applause. The Bible also tells fathers not to provoke their children to wrath, which means that impossible standards are a parent's failing, not a child's.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "Honor your father and mother, so that your days may be long in the land that the LORD your God is giving you" (Exodus 20:12).

> "Fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath; instead, bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord" (Ephesians 6:4).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- Nothing I do is ever enough.
- They will always find something wrong.
- I am a disappointment to them.
- If I try harder, maybe they will finally approve.
- I dread seeing them.
- I cannot relax around them.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know in advance how they will react.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should be able to win their approval.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either pleasing them or failing.
- Personalization: Treating their dissatisfaction as proof of my failure.

Challenging questions

- When did I first notice that nothing was ever enough?

- Is it possible that their dissatisfaction says more about them than about me?
- What would pleasing them completely look like, and has it ever been possible?
- What is the difference between honoring my parents and needing their approval?
- What does God say about me?
- What would change if I stopped trying to earn their applause?

Truth summary

> I can honor my parents without needing to win their approval. Their standards are not the measure of my worth. God accepts me in Christ, and I can live to please Him and serve people with a free heart.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Obedience
- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting
- Commandments

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can never please my parents"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can never please my parents." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did nothing become enough?
- ☐ What did they expect?
- ☐ What does honor look like without approval?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What will I say when criticized?
- ☐ What would freedom feel like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is not their approval.
- ☐ I can honor my parents without earning their praise.
- ☐ Impossible standards are not my fault.
- ☐ God accepts me in Christ.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I am free to live to please God.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Psalm 139:14**
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **Ephesians 6:4**
  "Fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath; instead, bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Approval or honor?: Each week, note one time you honored a parent without seeking approval.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 1:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can honor my parents and still live to please God.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the standard. Write what your parents expected and whether anyone could have met it.
- [ ] Practice honor without performance. Do one kind thing for a parent without hoping for praise.
- [ ] Plan for the visit. Before contact, decide in advance how you will respond calmly to criticism.
- [ ] Memorize Galatians 1:10. Say it before a difficult conversation.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can never please my parents": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honor without performance
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can never please my parents.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have worn myself out trying to please people who are never satisfied. Teach me to honor my parents and to rest in Your approval. Free me from the need to earn what You have already given. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #3 · PARENTS

“What my parents said about me must be true.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Children believe what their parents say. If we were told we were lazy, stupid, selfish, ugly, or “just like” a difficult relative, those words went in deeply, and we may still repeat them to ourselves. A parent’s words carry weight because they came at a time when we had no way to question them.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free.” Paul writes, “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind.” He also says, “We tear down arguments and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God; and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ.” God says of you, “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made,” and “we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works.” A parent’s words may have been repeated for years, but repetition does not make a statement true. Truth is tested against what God says.

> *“Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free”* (John 8:32).

Also see

> “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:14).

> “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life” (Ephesians 2:10).

> “We tear down arguments and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God; and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ” (2 Corinthians 10:5).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- They said I was worthless, so I must be.
- They know me best.
- I will always be the stupid one.
- I am exactly what they said I was.
- I cannot trust my own opinion of myself.
- If it was said so often, it must be true.

Common logical errors

- Authority bias: Accepting a statement as true because it came from a parent.
- Labeling: Carrying a childhood label into adulthood.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling flawed and treating the feeling as proof.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing evidence that contradicts the label.

Challenging questions

- What exactly did my parents say about me, in their words?
- Just because my parents said it, does that make it true?
- What evidence from my life supports it, and what contradicts it?
- What was going on in the parent who said it?
- What does God say about me instead?
- What would I say to a child who was told this?

Truth summary

> Words spoken over me are not the same as the truth about me. I can test what my parents said against Scripture and against the evidence of my life. God says I am fearfully and wonderfully made, and His word is the truth that sets me free.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Truth
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting
- Scripture/Word

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "What my parents said about me must be true"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What my parents said about me must be true." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly did my parents say?
- ☐ Is it true?
- ☐ What evidence contradicts it?
- ☐ What was happening in my parent?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What would I tell a child who heard it?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A statement is not true just because a parent said it.
- ☐ God's word is the truth that sets me free.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I am God's workmanship.
- ☐ I can take captive every thought.
- ☐ I can renew my mind.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 8:32
  "Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."
- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 10:5
  "We tear down arguments and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God; and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Lie and truth: Each time an old parental message appears, write the message and a truth from Scripture to answer it.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 139:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made, whatever I was told.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Thinking, Unhealthy" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write the messages. List what your parents said about you, one line each.
- ☐ Test each one. Beside each, write evidence for, evidence against, and what God says.
- ☐ Replace the label. Write a truthful sentence that replaces each message.
- ☐ Read your truth card daily. Read the replacement sentences aloud each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What my parents said about me must be true": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A lie answered
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What my parents said about me must be true.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, some words were spoken over me that I have believed for years. Show me what is true. Break the hold of every false message and renew my mind with Your word. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #4 · PARENTS

“I have to earn my parents' love.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Where affection was given for achievement and withdrawn for failure, children learn that love is a wage. Praise for grades, sports, or good behavior, and coldness for mistakes, teach that we are loved for what we do. As adults we may still perform for parents, or for others, hoping the reward will finally come.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” He says, “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works.” John writes, “We love because He first loved us.” God’s love is given before we do anything, and it is not taken back when we fail. A parent’s conditional love is a wound, but it does not set the terms for how God loves you, and you do not have to keep paying a debt you never owed.

> *“But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us”* (Romans 5:8).

Also see

> “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast” (Ephesians 2:8–9).

> “We love because He first loved us” (1 John 4:19).

> “Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me” (Psalm 27:10).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

Common self-statements

- If I stop achieving, they will stop caring.
- Love is something I have to deserve.
- I have to keep proving myself.
- When I fail, I lose their love.
- I must make them proud.
- Their love is always one mistake away.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting loss of love if I stop performing.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing love as either earned or absent.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must keep earning their approval.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling anxious about failing and treating it as proof of risk.

Challenging questions

- When did I first learn that love had a price?
- What happened when I failed or disappointed them?

- If their love really is conditional, whose problem is that?
- What is the difference between earning love and receiving it?
- How did God love me before I did anything?
- What would I do differently if I believed I was already loved?

Truth summary

> Love that must be earned is not the kind of love God gives. I am loved by God before I do anything. I can care for my parents and respect them without trying to purchase what should be freely given.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Grace
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting
- Salvation

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to earn my parents' love"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to earn my parents' love." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I learn love had a price?
- ☐ What happened when I failed?
- ☐ What does God's love require?
- ☐ Who gives me love freely?
- ☐ What would I do if I knew I was loved?
- ☐ What can I do with no reward?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's love is given, not earned.
- ☐ Christ died for me while I was still a sinner.
- ☐ I do not have to pay a debt I never owed.
- ☐ I love because He first loved me.
- ☐ Their conditions are not God's.
- ☐ I am loved before I do anything.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Ephesians 2:8–9
  "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."
- ☐ 1 John 4:19
  "We love because He first loved us."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Loved before doing: Each morning, say "I am loved before I do anything today," and note one task done from love, not fear.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 5:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ loved me while I was still a sinner, so I do not have to earn love.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Trace the price list. Write what you had to do to get approval as a child.
- [ ] Read Romans 5:8 slowly. Let it sink in that He loved you at your worst.
- [ ] Do something for no reward. Show kindness this week without expecting anything back.
- [ ] Share the story. Tell a trusted friend or counselor about the conditions you grew up with.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to earn my parents' love": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Loved before doing
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to earn my parents' love.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have worked for love all my life. Thank You that You loved me while I was still a sinner. Teach me to receive Your love as a gift and to stop paying for what You freely give. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #5 · PARENTS

“I can't be happy until my parents change.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When parents have hurt us, we may wait for an apology or a change that never comes. Holiday after holiday, we hope this will be the time they finally see us, and each disappointment reopens the wound. Waiting for them to change can quietly put our happiness in their hands.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says, “I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances,” which means that contentment is learned and is not handed to us by other people’s behavior. “Each of us will give an account of himself to God,” and “each one should carry his own load,” so I answer for my choices, and my parents answer for theirs. “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone,” and Proverbs says, “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life.” We can hope and pray for our parents to change, but our joy does not have to wait for them.

> *“For each one should carry his own load”* (Galatians 6:5).

Also see

> “So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God” (Romans 14:12).

> “I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances” (Philippians 4:11).

> “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

> “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life” (Proverbs 4:23).

Common self-statements

- I will never be at peace until they apologize.
- As long as they act this way, I cannot be happy.
- They ruined my life.
- My happiness depends on their changing.
- I cannot move on until they admit what they did.
- I am stuck until they change.

Common logical errors

- Externalizing control: Placing my happiness in someone else’s hands.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I cannot be happy while they stay the same.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either fixed by their change or stuck forever.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- How long have I been waiting for them to change?
- What has the waiting cost me?
- What parts of my life and happiness are in my control?
- What would it mean to hope for change and live well without it?

- What does Scripture say about contentment?
- Who or what can bring me joy now?

Truth summary

> I can hope for my parents to change and still choose to live well. My peace and joy are not owned by their choices. With God's help, I can grieve, set healthy limits, and build a good life now.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Parenting
- Thankful
- Peace
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be happy until my parents change"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

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Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be happy until my parents change." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How long have I waited?
- ☐ What has waiting cost me?
- ☐ What is mine to control?
- ☐ What can bring joy now?
- ☐ What limits do I need?
- ☐ What would contentment look like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My happiness is not in their hands.
- ☐ Each person answers to God for their own choices.
- ☐ I can learn to be content.
- ☐ I can guard my heart.
- ☐ I can live at peace as far as it depends on me.
- ☐ I can build a good life now.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 6:5
  "For each one should carry his own load."
- ☐ Philippians 4:11
  "I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances."
- ☐ Proverbs 4:23
  "Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Joy not waiting: Each day, write one thing that brought you joy that did not depend on your parents.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Philippians 4:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I have learned to be content, whatever my parents do.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Count the cost. Write what waiting for their change has cost you.
- ☐ Divide the control. List what is yours and what is theirs.
- ☐ Plan one good thing. Schedule something you enjoy this week.
- ☐ Set a limit if needed. Decide what contact is healthy for you and communicate it calmly.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be happy until my parents change": _____ % My truth: _____ %

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be happy until my parents change.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have waited a long time for them to change. Help me place my hope in You, release what is not mine to control, and build a good life with the joy You give. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.